

change people into controllable zombies, and how further genetic engineering can produce super-zombies.

STAR WARS

When the backstory of the clones from the Star Wars franchise was finally told in *Attack of the Clones*, we're told that the Kamino Cloners have used not just cloning, but also genetic engineering to enhance the clones to accelerate their growth rate and make them better and more obedient soldiers.

RINGWORLD

In Larry Niven's excellent *Ringworld* series, there is a character called Teela Brown who is descended from "lucky" ancestors. In the fictional world, lucky people win the birthright lottery, and are allowed to breed, and she is the result of six generations of consecutive winners, thus making her the luckiest person alive. This side story about her treats even how lucky people are as a genetic trait.

STAR TREK

Although there are many species that feature some form of genetic engineering in *Star Trek* (the various series and movies), Khan Noonien Singh (best known as just Khan), is a genetically modified human (or Augmented Human) who has been bred to be stronger, have more stamina and a higher intellect. However, whilst augmenting all these characteristics, what also gets amplified is his ambition, and he seeks to take over the universe and establish an augmented human race. (Sound familiar?)

ENDER'S GAME

In this excellent book series by Orson Scott Card, Ender Wiggin is a third child (a third is strictly frowned upon as one child too many in that time) who is allowed to be born only because of his parent's high intelligence in the hope that he can be put to military use. In the series, it is later revealed that another character named Bean is also genetically modified as a result of humanity's desperation to win a war against alien invaders, but in Bean's case, there are some awful side effects. We won't spoil the series for those of you who haven't read it. Highly recommended. There has also been a moderately good movie adaptation.

GATTACA

The movie *Gattaca* is set in a future where the human race is genetically modified and everyone has designer babies, because perfection is the norm. Everyone is gorgeous looking and super athletic, yet some people still cling to old ways and have children the natural way. These children are labeled invalids, and aren't given the same treatment as the perfect humans, and are denied the job opportunities. The story is brilliant and follows the path of one such invalid as he breaks all the rules, cheats and lies and does all he has to in order to accomplish his dreams.

THE LAST QUESTION

One of the best science fiction writers of all time, Isaac Asimov was better known for his *Robot* series and the laws of robotics, but he also wrote some pretty interesting short stories. One of our favourites is *The Last Question*, in which the entire evolution of mankind – billions of years into the future – is told beautifully as the buildup to a shock ending. It is a short story, and we encourage you to give it a read now: <http://dgit.in/LastQstn>

Write in and let us know if we've missed out on your favourite fictional treatment of genetic engineering. 

